THE BATTLE OF JUTLAND

At 2:00 a.m. on May 31, 1916, a scouting force of five battlecruisers under Admiral Franz von Hipper headed into the North Sea. An hour and a half behind him, Admiral Reinhard Scheer followed with 16 battleships of the German High Seas Fleet. With light cruisers and torpedo boats in support, almost a hundred German ships were at sea. Scheer's plan was for Hipper's scouting group to draw out part of the British Grand Fleet, which would then be surprised and destroyed by the German battleships.

Unbeknownst to the Germans, the Grand Fleet was already at sea. Royal Navy signals intelligence had detected that the High Seas Fleet was preparing to come out. With Admiral John Jellicoe in command, the Main Battle Fleet had set out from Scapa Flow after dark on May 30. Jellicoe intended to rendezvous with Sir David Beatty's Battlecruiser Force and destroy the High Seas Fleet. Instead of surprising an inferior Royal Navy force, Scheer would himself be surprised by an overwhelmingly superior British force of 151 warships, including 28 modern battleships.

Into the early afternoon of May 31, Jellicoe and Beatty's ships proceeded in quite leisurely fashion toward their rendezvous off Jutland, misled by a message from the Admiralty indicating that the High Seas Fleet had not yet left port. German commanders were equally ignorant of the movement of the Grand Fleet. U-boats in the North Sea had missed the British ships entirely while bad weather prevented the use of zeppelins for aerial reconnaissance. It was a surprise to both sides when, at around 2:20 p.m., two of Beatty's light cruisers sighted and engaged two of Hipper's torpedo boats.

BATTLECRUISER ACTION

As the first shots were fired, Beatty was steaming the wrong way, having just turned north to meet up with Jellicoe. He hastily turned south, a maneuver his 5th Battle Squadron was slow to follow. This was unfortunate, for the squadron's four Queen Elizabeth-class battleships would have given Beatty a clear superiority over Hipper. The five German and six British battlecruisers steamed on converging courses and sighted one another about an hour later. Hipper turned southeast to draw Beatty toward the High Seas Fleet. But since Scheer had inexplicably brought with him six slow-moving Deutschland-class pre-dreadnoughts his progress was not fast and there was time for Beatty to take on the German battlecruisers.

> "SUDDENLY MY PERISCOPE REVEALED SOME BIG SHIPS, BLACK MONSTERS; SIX TALL, BROAD-BEAMED GIANTS STEAMING IN TWO COLUMNS."
>
> **COMMANDER GEORG VON HASE**, GUNNERY OFFICER OF BATTLECRUISER *DERFFLINGER*, 1916

WORLD WAR I



THE BATTLE OF JUTLAND

Date	May 31–June 1, 1916
Location	North Sea off the coast of Denmark
Result	Inconclusive

COMBATANTS

BRITAIN	GERMANY

COMMANDERS

John Jellicoe	Reinhard Scheer

FORCES

Ships: 28 battleships, 9 battlecruisers, 8 armored cruisers, 106 other ships	**Ships:** 16 battleships, 5 battlecruisers, 6 pre-dreadnoughts, 72 other ships

LOSSES

Men: 6,094 **Ships:** 3 battlecruisers, 3 armored cruisers, 8 destroyers	**Men:** 2,551 **Ships:** 1 battlecruiser, 1 pre-dreadnought, 4 light cruisers, 5 destroyers

Webley Mark VI revolver
The Mark VI was a standard sidearm issued to British officers and boarding parties during WWI. The owner of this example served at Jutland on the *Temeraire*.

